



Long wait: The last time EBFC celebrated a triumph of similar magnitude was when the club won the National Football League titles in 2003 and 2004. PTI

Football League eventually gave way to the I-League. That, in turn, was eclipsed by the emergence of the glitzy ISL following the arrival of the Reliance-backed Football Sports Development Limited (FSDL) in Indian football administration in 2010.

More than two decades without a league title created a deep sense of despair among supporters, many of whom grew up hearing stories of the club's glorious past without witnessing similar achievements

themselves. Cup triumphs provided moments of relief, but the ultimate marker of national supremacy, the league title, remained elusive.

The wait became even more painful as success continued unabated across the city at Mohun Bagan Super Giant, which collected league honours across every major phase of Indian football's evolution, from the National Football League to the I-League and eventually the ISL.

The 12th edition of the ISL arrived at a significant moment in Indian football administration. It marked the departure of FSDL as the league's promoter, with operational control returning to the All India Football Federation. The transition created uncertainty and logistical challenges, forcing the financially

strained federation to organise a truncated single-leg round-robin tournament featuring 14 teams, including newly-promoted Inter Kashi FC.

Mohun Bagan entered the season as the holder of the ISL double crown, the League Shield, and ISL Cup, a distinction previously achieved only by Mumbai City FC. Carrying forward much of its title-winning squad, Mohun Bagan began the campaign strongly and appeared poised to continue its dominance.

However, a major weakness emerged in away fixtures. Despite remaining difficult to beat, Mohun Bagan won only one of its four away matches, drawing the remaining three. Those dropped points proved